unequivocal indication of Hanafi affiliation has been recovered from the extensive epigraphic program of the Ghazna palace. Nevertheless, Juzjani claimed that upon being crowned sultan of Ghazna, Mu'izz al-Din, "in conformity with the people of the city of Ghazna and its environs, accepted the *madhhab* of the exalted Imam [Abu Hanifa]." The westerly *qibla* orientations of the Ghazna Shansabanis' architectural traces along the Indus, then, would have been consistent with their new avowal of Hanafi juridico-legal affiliation.[5]

Indus Bound

Nothing like the disappointment of an elder, the inertia of historical momentum, and a little good luck to act as impetuses for ambitious actions with reverberations well beyond one's own lifetime! This convergence of factors could partially serve to explain – as plausibly as any other – the tireless campaigns of territorial expansion and consolidation that the recently crowned Sultan Mu'izz al-Din undertook within four to five years after taking possession of Ghazna and the erstwhile Yamini territories of southern Afghanistan. Mu'izz al-Din's eastward campaigns increasingly differentiated his new Shansabani lineage based at Ghazna from his agnates at Firuzkuh and Bamiyan. Furthermore – and, of course, unbeknownst to Mu'izz al-Din at the time – the spectacular victories of his military forces, extending ever deeper into the Indian subcontinent, were to have irreversible *longue durée* ramifications for the flow of people, ideas, and things between the larger Indic and Iranian cultural worlds.

I argued in Chapter 5 that the Ghazna Shansabanis' expansionist ambitions, and the underlying motivations behind the numerous and ambitious campaigns early on in Mu'izz al-Din's reign, did not appear out of nowhere. Rather, they came as the inextricable inheritance of conquering Ghazna, which was integrated into networks of commerce and communication that were strongly oriented toward India, and geo-politically poised for eastward imperialism. In important recent works, Waleed Ziad and Ali Anooshahr have both compellingly proposed that, ever since the first decade of Mahmud Ghaznavi's reign (AH 389–421/999–1030 CE), "the relationship of the Ghaznavid court with Hindu India was not simply one of predatory violence, but imperial over-lordship".[6] While the majority of historical authors patronized by the Ghaznavid rulers emphasized the near annual campaigns into northern India by Mahmud and Mas'ud I (r. AH 421–432/1030–1041 CE) as raids for plunder and destruction of "idol-houses" or temples, other important evidentiary sources indicate that the Ghaznavids' aims were more encompassing, their victories aimed at gaining rights of sovereignty in India (see the following sections of this chapter).